mausoleum was complete, but work on the outer grounds continued for another decade. Finished entirely by 1653, the structure sat proudly framed by four thin towers of white stone. Upon the approach, there was a vast, shallow pool. The main building was roofed by a series of Persian domes and studded with archways. Everything appeared serene, peaceful, magnificent, and dazzlingly white. Shah Jahan had fulfilled his promise to house the empress in the greatest monument the world had ever seen.

In addition to the mausoleum itself, the emperor had two more edifices constructed, both in line with the central structure and each facing it from the west and east. From the west lay a mosque; from the east, a rest house. These are of great significance to both the deceased empress and her husband since Islamic tradition states that women who die in childbirth are martyrs. Therefore, their resting places become locations of pilgrimage for the devout near and far. In anticipation of these visitors, Shah Jahan prepared a church in which they could pray and a space in which they could rest from their long and tedious journeys. The guest house, called a mehmaan khana, was a formal nod to the Indian tradition of entertaining travelers and guests in comfortable, amicable accommodations.

Shah Jahan died at the age of 74 in 1666, having lost his lust for leadership and suffered the usurpation of the throne by his son, Aurangzeb. His body was interred next to that of his first love, the Empress Mumtaz Mahal, in the splendid mausoleum he had built for her.